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THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING



Cyberattack disrupts Mackay Sugar operations, exposing growing agri-industrial cyber risks

Threat Actor Profile

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Cyberattack Disrupts Mackay Sugar Operations, Exposing Growing Agri-Industrial Cyber Risks

1. Executive Summary

Lost Boys Cyber assesses with **medium confidence** that the June 2026 Mackay Sugar cyber incident represents a financially motivated ransomware intrusion against an agri-industrial operator where business, cane-supply, logistics, and potentially adjacent OT-dependent production processes were disrupted at operationally significant scale. Mackay Sugar publicly confirmed a cyber security incident affecting some operations, engaged specialist cyber security experts, reported the matter to relevant authorities, and prioritized worker safety, operational-system protection, and controlled restoration.

The most operationally important outcome was not public data theft; it was loss of confidence in the systems required to crush cane safely and coordinate cane supply. Reporting from Mackay Sugar, ABC News, Industrial Cyber, and sector press indicates that Farleigh and Racecourse mills stopped milling and cane haulage, growers were directed to cease harvesting, and Mackay Sugar later restarted limited manual crushing at Farleigh to process cane harvested before the incident while cane-supply and logistics systems remained under restoration.

Attribution remains provisional. Mackay Sugar has not publicly confirmed ransomware, data exfiltration, or the affected technical systems. SecurityWeek and Security Affairs reported that **The Gentlemen** ransomware operation, tracked by Microsoft as **Storm-2697**, named Mackay Sugar on its Tor-based leak site on 2026-06-15. Because the victim has not validated the claim and no public leak data was observed in the reviewed sources, Lost Boys Cyber treats the Gentlemen attribution as **medium confidence** and the data-theft claim as **unconfirmed**.

For defenders in food, agriculture, manufacturing, and OT-heavy logistics environments, the incident highlights a practical risk: ransomware does not need direct PLC manipulation to disrupt production. Compromise of scheduling, identity, remote administration, ERP, historian-adjacent, rail/haulage coordination, or mill intake systems can force a safe shutdown while operators validate whether industrial processes can continue without trusted digital support.

Field	Assessment
Report ID	LBC-TAP-2026-006
Primary victim	Mackay Sugar Limited, Queensland, Australia
Sector	Food and agriculture; sugar milling; manufacturing; agri-industrial logistics
Incident window	Publicly disclosed 2026-06-10; operational updates through at least 2026-06-15
Suspected actor	The Gentlemen ransomware / Storm-2697, unconfirmed by victim
Confidence	Medium for incident impact; medium for ransomware attribution; low for data-theft impact
Primary risk	Operational disruption through IT, logistics, and OT-adjacent dependencies
Defensive priority	Segment production-critical services, harden identity and remote administration, validate manual operations, monitor ransomware lateral movement and mass encryption precursors

2. Intelligence Requirement

This report answers the following priority intelligence requirements (PIRs) for Lost Boys Cyber clients operating in manufacturing, agriculture, food processing, and OT-adjacent logistics environments.

PIR	Current Answer	Confidence	Defensive Implication
What happened to Mackay Sugar?	A cyber security incident disrupted some operations, causing Farleigh and Racecourse milling/cane haulage to stop and growers to cease harvesting while recovery proceeded.	High	Treat business-system outages as production-impacting events when they gate safe process operations.
Was ransomware involved?	Public cyber reporting attributes the incident to The Gentlemen ransomware; Mackay Sugar has not confirmed ransomware or data theft.	Medium	Prepare for ransomware-style containment and extortion even when public statements use neutral “cyber incident” language.
Did the attacker directly compromise OT?	No reviewed public source confirms direct ICS/PLC compromise. Operational impact may have resulted from compromised IT, logistics, cane-supply, or operational-support systems.	Low/Medium	Defenders should monitor IT/OT boundary systems and production-support applications, not only PLCs.
Why does this matter beyond sugar production?	The outage occurred early in crushing season and created time-sensitive pressure because cut cane loses sugar content if not processed quickly.	High	Cyber resilience plans must account for commodity perishability, seasonal production windows, and safety validation delays.
What should similar organizations hunt for now?	Credential theft, suspicious remote administration, abnormal SMB/admin-share access, mass file modification, backup tampering, shadow-copy deletion, scheduled-task/psexec-style lateral movement, and abnormal access to logistics/production-support systems.	Medium	Detection engineering should combine enterprise telemetry with OT-adjacent asset and business-process context.

Assumptions used in this assessment:

- The incident materially affected production-support systems even if the attacker did not directly manipulate industrial controllers.
- “The Gentlemen” attribution is treated as reporting-derived and unconfirmed by Mackay Sugar.
- No victim-specific indicators of compromise were publicly available in the reviewed sources; detection content therefore focuses on behavior and tradecraft rather than unique IOCs.

3. Source Review and Confidence

The source base is sufficient to confirm operational disruption and recovery posture, but insufficient to prove initial access vector, affected systems, exact malware family, or data-exfiltration impact. Lost Boys Cyber assigns the incident impact assessment ****high confidence****, the The Gentlemen attribution ****medium confidence****, and victim-specific technical details ****low confidence**** until Mackay Sugar, ACSC, law enforcement, or a security vendor releases more detail.

Source	Contribution	Reliability / Credibility	Confidence Notes
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Mackay Sugar public incident statements, 2026-06-10 and 2026-06-12	Primary victim confirmation of cyber incident, safety priorities, specialist response, authority notification, interim processes, limited manual crushing, and staged restoration.	A / 1 for victim posture	Best source for what the victim is willing to confirm; does not identify attacker, intrusion path, or data impact.
ABC News, 2026-06-10 and 2026-06-12	Local operational reporting: Farleigh and Racecourse shutdown, grower cease-harvesting notices, cane-haulage disruption, manual crushing to protect already cut cane.	B / 2	Strong corroboration of operational consequences and local stakeholder impact.
Industrial Cyber, 2026-06-12	Sector framing: food/agriculture supply-chain risk, OT/logistics interdependence, 1,300 farms supplying Mackay Sugar mills.	B / 2	Useful for industrial-risk context; relies partly on victim statement and local reporting.
SecurityWeek and Security Affairs, 2026-06-15	Attribution reporting that The Gentlemen ransomware group claimed Mackay Sugar on a Tor leak site.	B / 2	Attribution is plausible but remains unconfirmed by the victim; no public leak data observed in reviewed material.
Microsoft Threat Intelligence reporting on The Gentlemen / Storm-2697, 2026-05	Background on the actor/RaaS model, Go-based ransomware, self-propagation, and affiliate operations.	A / 2	Actor TTP context, not victim-specific evidence.
AhnLab/ASEC, Trend Micro, SC Media, and other ransomware-trend reporting	Context on The Gentlemen activity across manufacturing, healthcare, construction, and other critical sectors.	B / 2-3	Useful for threat-pattern validation; not determinative for this incident.

Key confidence caveats:

- No public Mackay Sugar statement reviewed by Lost Boys Cyber confirms ransomware, data theft, or direct industrial-control compromise.
- No public victim-specific hashes, C2 infrastructure, ransom note, leak-site sample, or forensic timeline were available at time of writing.
- The actor profile is therefore a defensive profile for a likely ransomware disruption scenario, not a final forensic attribution report.

4. Key Findings

Finding	Severity	Confidence	Evidence	Defensive Meaning
The incident caused direct production disruption at Farleigh and Racecourse mills.	High	High	Mackay Sugar and ABC reporting described stopped milling/cane haulage and later limited manual crushing at Farleigh.	Production-support system compromise can force safety-driven mill shutdowns even without public evidence of PLC manipulation.

Cane-supply and logistics systems were a central recovery dependency.	High	High	Mackay Sugar stated key cane supply and logistics systems remained under restoration and no additional cane was being accepted as of the 2026-06-12 update.	Scheduling, rail/haulage, intake, and ERP-like systems should be treated as production-critical assets.
Timing amplified business impact because the incident occurred early in crushing season.	Medium/High	High	ABC reported that Farleigh and Racecourse had started crushing within the past week and cane must be processed quickly after cutting.	Incident response plans must include seasonal operating constraints and degraded/manual mode runbooks.
Public reporting links the incident to The Gentlemen ransomware, but victim confirmation is absent.	Medium	Medium	SecurityWeek/Security Affairs reporting tied the event to The Gentlemen / Storm-2697 leak-site activity.	Defenders should prepare for double-extortion and lateral-encryption tradecraft but avoid overclaiming attribution.
No public victim-specific IOCs are available.	Medium	High	Reviewed public reporting did not disclose hashes, domains, IPs, ransom notes, or affected product names.	Hunting must be behavior-led and mapped to enterprise/OT-adjacent telemetry.
The event is a warning case for food and agriculture critical infrastructure.	High	High	The outage touched grower operations, cane haulage, mill intake, and commodity-processing timing.	Cyber tabletop exercises should explicitly model supply-chain coordination failures and manual recovery controls.

Operational timeline from reviewed sources:

Date	Event	Source Confidence
2026-06-10	Mackay Sugar disclosed a cyber security incident affecting some operations and prioritized safety, operational systems, and business continuity.	High
2026-06-10	Local growers and harvesting contractors were instructed to cease harvesting; Farleigh and Racecourse milling/cane haulage stopped.	High
2026-06-12	Mackay Sugar reported limited manual crushing at Farleigh for already harvested cane; key cane-supply/logistics systems remained under restoration and no additional cane was accepted.	High
2026-06-12	Mackay Sugar anticipated staged resumption of harvesting and crushing from	High

	the following week, subject to restoration and validation.	
2026-06-15	Security reporting stated The Gentlemen ransomware group claimed Mackay Sugar on a Tor leak site.	Medium

5. Threat Context

The Mackay Sugar disruption aligns with a broader ransomware pattern affecting OT-heavy and logistics-dependent organizations. The operational impact does not require an attacker to control industrial equipment directly. If an attacker compromises the systems that authenticate users, coordinate cane deliveries, manage rail/haulage, sequence mill intake, provide engineering workstations with trusted files, or support safety validation, operators may be forced to stop or degrade production until safe-state and recovery checks are complete.

The Gentlemen, tracked by Microsoft as Storm-2697, is reported as a financially motivated ransomware-as-a-service ecosystem. Public technical reporting describes a Go-based ransomware family with aggressive propagation, double-extortion pressure, affiliate-based intrusion operations, and interest in critical sectors such as manufacturing, healthcare, construction, transportation, education, and finance. Reporting from ASEC, Microsoft, Trend Micro, SC Media, and Security Affairs indicates the group's model includes rapid lateral movement, credential-enabled access, and extortion branding through a Tor leak site.

If The Gentlemen attribution is accurate, the most likely high-level intrusion phases are:

Phase	Likely Behavior	Defensive Telemetry
Initial Access	Stolen credentials, exposed remote access, phishing, vulnerable edge services, or affiliate-provided access.	Identity provider logs, VPN logs, EDR sign-in telemetry, firewall/VPN concentrator events.
Discovery	Domain, share, backup, virtualization, file-server, and production-support system discovery.	PowerShell, net.exe, nltest, LDAP queries, unusual admin enumeration, OT jump-host activity.
Lateral Movement	SMB/admin shares, remote services, scheduled tasks, PsExec-like behavior, RDP, remote management tooling.	Windows Event IDs 4624/4627/4648/4697/4698/7045, EDR process/network telemetry, SMB flows.
Defense Evasion	Security tooling tamper attempts, backup service stopping, shadow-copy deletion, log clearing, process termination.	Event IDs 1102/104, service-control events, vssadmin/wbadmin/bcdedit/wevtutil execution.
Impact	Mass file encryption, business-system outage, leak-site pressure, operational shutdown until systems are validated.	High-volume file rename/write, ransom-note creation, abnormal file extensions, backup failures, helpdesk reports, production downtime.

MITRE ATT&CK mapping for defender alignment:

Tactic	Technique	ID	Relevance
Initial Access	Valid Accounts	T1078	Ransomware affiliates often enter using stolen credentials or brokered access.
Execution	Command and Scripting Interpreter	T1059	Common for discovery, staging, and recovery-disruptive scripts.

Persistence / Privilege Escalation	Scheduled Task/Job	T1053	Common ransomware deployment and propagation mechanism.
Defense Evasion	Impair Defenses	T1562	Relevant to AV/EDR tampering and disabling recovery controls.
Credential Access	OS Credential Dumping	T1003	Used to expand ransomware blast radius after initial access.
Discovery	Network Service Discovery	T1046	Used to identify file servers, domain systems, and production-support services.
Lateral Movement	SMB/Windows Admin Shares	T1021.002	Common path for ransomware deployment across Windows estates.
Command and Control	Ingress Tool Transfer	T1105	Used to stage ransomware, exfiltration tools, or remote utilities.
Exfiltration	Exfiltration Over Web Service	T1567	Relevant if double-extortion staging occurred.
Impact	Data Encrypted for Impact	T1486	Core ransomware impact hypothesis.
Impact	Inhibit System Recovery	T1490	Shadow-copy and backup disruption are priority hunt targets.
Impact	Service Stop	T1489	Stopping backup, database, or production-support services can magnify disruption.

6. Detection and Hunting

Because no victim-specific IOCs were publicly released, the following detection package prioritizes reusable behaviors for agri-industrial ransomware scenarios. Tune all queries to known admin tooling, maintenance windows, OT jump-host naming conventions, and sanctioned backup software before enabling production alerting.

6.1 Detection Coverage Matrix

Analytic Goal	Telemetry Source	Detection Strategy	Priority
Detect mass encryption or ransomware staging	EDR file/process telemetry, Windows Sysmon, file-server audit logs	Identify high-volume file modifications, ransom-note creation, abnormal file extensions, and encryption tools launched from user-writable paths.	Critical
Detect backup and recovery sabotage	Windows process/service logs, backup platform logs	Alert on vssadmin, wbadmin, bcdedit, wevtutil, service stop, backup catalog deletion, and snapshot deletion.	Critical

Detect lateral movement to production-support systems	EDR network telemetry, Windows logon events, firewall logs	Baseline admin-share, RDP, WinRM, and remote-service use between IT, OT DMZ, engineering, and logistics hosts.	High
Detect compromised identity use	IdP, VPN, AD, PAM logs	Monitor impossible travel, new device sign-ins, unusual admin group use, off-hours VPN, and anomalous MFA fatigue/approval patterns.	High
Detect data staging/exfiltration	Proxy, DNS, firewall, DLP, EDR network logs	Hunt archive creation followed by unusual outbound transfers to cloud storage, VPS, or Tor/proxy infrastructure.	High
Detect production-support disruption	Application, historian, logistics, ERP, rail/haulage, mill-intake logs	Alert on service stops, authentication failures, database connectivity loss, and unusual privilege changes in cane-supply/logistics systems.	High

6.2 Sigma: Ransomware Recovery Sabotage and Mass-Impact Precursors

```

title: Agri-Industrial Ransomware Recovery Sabotage Commands
id: 16b0e305-ec7e-4b7f-a8b8-mackay-sugar-behavioral
status: experimental
description: Detects Windows commands frequently used before or during ransomware impact to impair recovery, clear evidence, or disable boot recovery. Tune for sanctioned backup administration.
author: Lost Boys Cyber
date: 2026-06-16
references:
  - https://www.mkysugar.com.au/news-updates-circulars/mackay-sugar-cyber-security-incident
  - https://www.abc.net.au/news/2026-06-12/mackay-sugar-mills-shut-by-cyber-attack-hope-to-reopen-next-week/106792420
  - https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/security/blog/2026/05/28/the-gentlemen-ransomware-dissecting-a-self-propagating-go-encryptor/
tags:
  - attack.impact
  - attack.t1486
  - attack.t1490
  - attack.t1489
logsource:
  product: windows
  category: process_creation
detection:
  selection_img:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\\vssadmin.exe'
      - '\\wmic.exe'
      - '\\wbadmin.exe'
      - '\\bcdedit.exe'
      - '\\wevtutil.exe'
      - '\\powershell.exe'
      - '\\cmd.exe'
  selection_cmd:
    CommandLine|contains:
      - 'delete shadows'
      - 'shadowcopy delete'
      - 'wbadmin delete catalog'
      - 'recoveryenabled no'
      - 'bootstatuspolicy ignoreallfailures'

```

```

- 'delete catalog'
- 'Clear-EventLog'
- 'wevtutil cl'
- 'stop-service'
- 'net stop'
filter_backup_admin:
  User|contains:
    - 'backup'
    - 'svc_veeam'
    - 'svc_commvault'
  condition: selection_img and selection_cmd and not filter_backup_admin
fields:
- UtcTime
- Computer
- User
- Image
- CommandLine
- ParentImage
falsepositives:
- Approved backup maintenance
- Disaster-recovery testing
level: high

```

6.3 Microsoft Defender XDR Hunt: Lateral Movement and Impact on Production-Support Hosts

```

let lookback = 30d;
let ProductionKeywords = dynamic(["mill", "cane", "haul", "logistics", "weigh", "intake", "scada",
"historian", "otdmz", "farleigh", "racecourse", "marian"]);
let RansomwareTools = dynamic(["vssadmin.exe", "wbadmin.exe", "bcdedit.exe", "wevtutil.exe",
"psxessvc.exe", "psExec.exe", "nltest.exe", "net.exe", "net1.exe", "wmic.exe", "powershell.exe"]);
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(lookback)
| where FileName in~ (RansomwareTools)
  or ProcessCommandLine has_any ("delete shadows", "shadowcopy", "recoveryenabled no",
"bootstatuspolicy", "wevtutil cl", "admin$", "c$", "schtasks", "net stop")
| extend production_context = iff(DeviceName has_any (ProductionKeywords) or ProcessCommandLine has_any
(ProductionKeywords), "production-support", "enterprise")
| summarize first_seen=min(Timestamp), last_seen=max(Timestamp), command_count=count(),
commands=make_set(ProcessCommandLine, 20), parents=make_set(InitiatingProcessFileName, 10) by
DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, production_context
| where command_count >= 2 or production_context == "production-support"
| order by last_seen desc

```

6.4 Splunk Hunt: SMB/Admin-Share Burst Toward OT-Adjacent Assets

```

index=edr OR index=windows OR index=network earliest=-30d
((dest_port=445 OR DestinationPort=445 OR CommandLine="*ADMIN$" OR CommandLine="*C$") OR
(EventCode=5140 OR EventCode=4624))
| eval target=coalesce(dest, DestinationHostname, ComputerName, host)
| eval src=coalesce(src, SourceHostname, WorkstationName, IPAddress)
| eval production_target=if(match(lower(target), "mill|cane|haul|logistics|weigh|intake|scada|
historian|otdmz|farleigh|racecourse|marian"), "yes", "no")
| stats count dc(target) as unique_targets values(target) as targets values(user) as users
values(CommandLine) as commands by src, production_target, span=1h
| where count > 25 OR unique_targets > 10 OR production_target="yes"
| sort - count

```

6.5 YARA-Lite Filename/Ransom-Note Triage for File Servers

```

rule LBC_AgriIndustrial_Ransomware_Note_Triage
{
  meta:
    description = "Generic triage for ransomware note patterns on file shares; not specific to Mackay
Sugar or The Gentlemen"
    author = "Lost Boys Cyber"
    date = "2026-06-16"
    confidence = "low-medium"

```

```

strings:
  $s1 = "your files have been encrypted" nocase
  $s2 = "data leak" nocase
  $s3 = "tor browser" nocase
  $s4 = "decrypt" nocase
  $s5 = "do not rename" nocase
  $s6 = "contact us" nocase
condition:
  filesize < 500KB and 3 of ($s*)
}

```

7. Recommendations

Priority	Owner	Recommendation	Rationale
Critical	CISO / OT Security Lead	Classify cane supply, weighbridge, haulage, rail, mill-intake, historian-adjacent, ERP, and identity services as production-critical dependencies.	These systems can stop production even when PLCs remain uncompromised.
Critical	Infrastructure / Backup Owners	Validate immutable/offline backups for domain controllers, file servers, logistics systems, historian databases, engineering workstations, and critical application servers.	Ransomware recovery depends on clean backups and known-good restoration order.
Critical	SOC / Detection Engineering	Deploy behavioral detections for shadow-copy deletion, backup tampering, service stops, mass file modification, remote scheduled tasks, and SMB/admin-share bursts.	Public IOCs are absent; behavior-led detection is required.
High	Identity / IAM	Enforce phishing-resistant MFA for VPN, remote access, cloud admin, privileged accounts, and third-party support accounts; review stale accounts and emergency access.	Ransomware affiliates commonly use stolen or brokered credentials.
High	Network / OT Engineering	Revalidate segmentation between enterprise IT, OT DMZ, engineering workstations, historian, safety systems, and production-support applications.	Segmentation limits ransomware blast radius and preserves safe manual operations.
High	Operations / Plant Management	Maintain tested manual/degraded-mode procedures for intake, haulage coordination, weighbridge operation, and controlled crushing restart.	Mackay Sugar's limited manual crushing shows recovery depends on safe manual fallbacks.
High	Incident Response	Create a seasonal cyber incident playbook that accounts for	Commodity timing can turn a short cyber outage into material

		perishability, harvest windows, transport constraints, and grower communications.	economic loss.
Medium	Legal / Communications	Prepare public and partner communication templates that distinguish confirmed facts from attribution, ransomware, and data-theft claims.	Neutral, accurate communications reduce rumor-driven pressure while preserving investigative integrity.
Medium	Procurement / Third-Party Risk	Review remote access, support paths, and cyber requirements for vendors supporting mill automation, logistics, weighbridge, rail, ERP, and backup platforms.	Third-party access is a common path into OT-adjacent environments.

Implementation guidance for agri-industrial defenders:

- Run a tabletop exercise using a scenario where enterprise identity and logistics systems are compromised during peak harvest, but direct PLC compromise is unknown.
- Define the minimum telemetry set required before restarting production: endpoint health, domain controller integrity, backup integrity, OT jump-host status, engineering workstation validation, application/database integrity, and safety-system independence.
- Pre-stage contact lists and communication templates for growers, contractors, regulators, cyber insurers, law enforcement, and critical suppliers.
- Keep a paper/manual fallback for dispatching, weighing, quality sampling, and intake decisions where safety and regulatory obligations permit.
- Monitor public ransomware leak sites through a legal/compliance-approved process, but do not treat leak-site claims as confirmed attribution without corroborating forensic evidence.

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